



IIT PALAKKAD



5th EDITION
Feb, 2022

FOOTPRINTS

ALUMNI CELL

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ACCOMPLISHMENTS

Ph.D. student in the Electrical Engineering Department, Mr. A. N. Madhavanunni, under the guide, Dr. Mahesh R. Panicker, has been selected as a Finalist in the Student Paper Competition for the 43rd Annual International Conference of the IEEE Engineering in Medicine and Biology Society (IEEE EMBC 2021). EMBC is the flagship conference of IEEE Engineering in Medicine and Biology Society. Madhavanunni is one of the 10 finalists in the open category, and only 2 students from Asia have been selected this year.

Dr. Manas Kumar Jena who is an Assistant Professor in the Electrical Engineering Department has received the INAE Young Engineer Award 2021 in Power Systems Engineering

During the DAE Symposium on Current Trends in Theoretical Chemistry, organized by the Chemistry Division, BARC, Mumbai, Ms. Nayana E C, a Ph.D. student working with Dr. Padmesh in the chemistry department received the best poster presentation award.

Mr. Jibin Boban, a Ph.D. scholar working with Dr. Afzaal Ahmed in the Mechanical Department has received 'student Award' based on the recommendation of the scientific committee for the content of his paper at the 4th World Congress on Micro and Nano Manufacturing (WCMNM) conference held at IIT Bombay during September 2021 for his work submitted "Surface micro-layer modification of selectively laser melted TiAl alloy using wire electrical discharge polishing".

Mr. Narayanan P. P from Electrical Engineering has been selected for the very prestigious PMRF fellowship scheme.

Dr. Sukomal Dey, Assistant Professor in the Discipline of Electrical Engineering, has been awarded the IETE- Smt Ranjana Pal Memorial Award 2021. The award, from the Institution of Electronics & Telecommunication Engineers, is in recognition of his contributions and significant achievements in the field of RF Communications, Electromagnetics, Antennas, Microwaves, and high-frequency electronics during the last five years.

INSTITUTE UPDATES

New Academic Administrative Structure At IIT Palakkad

Following the approval of the Board of Governors in the 10th meeting held on September 25, 2021, the institute has transitioned into a new academic administrative structure consisting of departments and centres, containing ten departments and one interdisciplinary research centre which will be headed by the respective Head of Department/Centre as listed below along with their email-ids :

- a. Department of Biological Sciences and Engineering: Prof. Jagadeesh Bayry (hodbse@)
- b. Department of Chemistry: Dr. Dinesh Jagadeesan (hodcy@)
- c. Department of Civil Engineering: Dr. M. V. Anil Kumar (hodce@)
- d. Department of Computer Science and Engineering: Dr. Jasine Babu (hodcs@)
- e. Department of Data Science: Dr. Mrinal Kanti Das (HoD In-charge) (hodds@)
- f. Department of Electrical Engineering: Dr. Mahesh R Panicker (hodee@)
- g. Department of Humanities and Social Sciences: Dr. Reenu Punnoose (hodhss@)
- h. Department of Mathematics: Dr. M. Ashok Kumar (hodma@)
- i. Department of Mechanical Engineering: Dr. Samarjeet Chanda (hodme@)
- j. Department of Physics: Dr. Jayakumar Balakrishnan (hodph@)
- k. Environmental Sciences and Sustainable Engineering Centre (ESSENCE): Dr. Deepak Jaiswal (hocess@)

Dr. Deepak Rajendraprasad, who was the Associate Dean (Academics, UG) of IIT Palakkad for the last two years, completed his term. Dr. Sudheesh T.K., Assistant Professor in the discipline of Civil Engineering has taken over as the Associate Dean (Academics, UG) at IIT Palakkad.

Convocation 2021

The 2nd and 3rd convocations of IIT Palakkad were held together on 25th September 2021. Shri. M. M. Murugappan, Former Chairman, Murugappa Group, was the Chief Guest and Prof. Ramesh Venkateswaran, Chairman of the Board of Governors of IIT Palakkad presided over the Convocation. Shri. M. M. Murugappan inaugurated the Auditorium, named AGORA, at Nila Campus, and the Cement Relief Mural, on the Manogatha wall, was dedicated to the Class of 2020 and Class of 2021 at 12.00 noon.

Ms. Kavitha GR has been appointed as the Manager - International and Alumni Relations at IIT Palakkad

Industry-Academia Conclave (IAC) 3.0

The third edition of the Industry-Academia Conclave (IAC) 3.0 was conducted in online mode for 2 days. The conclave had eminent industrialists and personalities presenting about the topic of their expertise and interacting with the students of IIT Palakkad. The students presented their projects on the second day.

As a part of Independence Day Celebrations, "Unity run 2.0" was conducted from Nila to Permanent Campus.

COVACKATHON

Technology Innovation Foundation of IIT Palakkad (TECHIN) along with the Kerala Government, the Startup Mission, Maker Village, Kerala Digital University, and Junction-P had conducted a 4-day Hackathon, COVACKATHON to engage the national startup energies to help the state and country get back on its feet. The event also included talks from eminent personalities, panel discussions, and workshops

EPIGRAMS

The most memorable moments of your B.Tech Life

"Night tea and frequent visits to the hilltop at nila campus with friends. Mini militia ,PUBG, gym, music sessions and Night outs in rain at Ahalia."

If you get a chance to take one person with you back to the hostel who would it be?

"Maybe Naveen because he is rich and always has food in his cupboard."

What is one thing you wanted to do in your B.Tech life but couldn't do?

"Study what I actually liked. I regret not taking my favorite branch!"

If you were in charge of planning a concert for the college, which two artists/speakers would you bring?

- "1) Aishwarya Rai - She is gorgeous!
- 2) Arjith Singh - He sings so damn good!"



Ashwin K Raghu

Alumnus B'16,
ME

The most memorable moments of your B.Tech Life

"If I was made to choose It might be tough, but yes After successfully completing any and all events, those moments were full of emotions, friends from hostel and afar coordinating and celebrating your birthday always made me feel thankful, and obviously winning and losing elections left quite an impression too helping me introspect myself."

If you get a chance to take one person with you back to the hostel who would it be?

"It might feel like a diplomatic answer, but TBH, I never really felt the closest per say to one person, so if it's one person I think it'd be Dr. Arvind Ajoy sir."

What is one thing you wanted to do in your B.Tech life but couldn't do?

"Fulfill the larger vision of mine for the college, which I failed to do during my tenure at college. That was a lesson for me too, if I could change one thing ... Then it'd be that instead of micromanaging I'd rather trust them and focus on my vision and mission for the college's tech culture and also as a whole."

If you were in charge of planning a concert for the college, which two artists/speakers would you bring?

"Well, over here my view is quite biased, one would be a renowned scientist from one of the many prestigious institutions established in Kerala, the other would be someone from the theatre world. The time I have spent there I have seen people rise from the unknown when it came to tech or academics, with or without help, with talent or sheer hard work and perseverance. Hence I strongly believe that we still have a lot of untapped potential as a Technological institute with just the current population and facilities. That would be the reason for the scientist. Secondly I also believe that people are a little more hesitant to join the drama club but what I'd hope to achieve with that is he/she can make everyone realise how it is deeply engraved into our everyday lives, how it can be both natural and even therapeutic for some."



Sachin Rustagi

Alumnus B'16,
EE

The most memorable moments of your B.Tech Life

“Being elected as the General Secretary of the college, the Goa trip in the final semester and of course, the Graduation Ceremony. Apart from that, I really miss the post-dinner walks with my friends, random late night conversations and the frequent Coimbatore/Palakkad visits with them.”

If you get a chance to take one person with you back to the hostel who would it be?

“Obviously, I would want to be with all my dear friends if I go back to hostel. We experienced it for a bit during convocation and it was delightful. Choosing a single person is very difficult. Dhakad, Gupta, Shyam, Balu, Vismay,..... the list goes on and on.”

What is one thing you wanted to do in your B.Tech life but couldn't do?

“There were a lot of things in my bucket list, to be done in the final semester of B.Tech, but unfortunately we had to pack our bags and leave the college due to COVID. Going on a trip to the Himalayas with my buddies was one of them.”

If you were in charge of planning a concert for the college, which two artists/speakers would you bring?

“Firstly I would bring the famous stand-up comedian, Munawar Faruqui as I love his stand-up comedy shows and have attended one of them. Then I would bring Lucky Ali to the concert for his melodious voice which makes people go nostalgic.”



Afroz Shaikh

Alumnus B'16,
EE

The most memorable moments of your B.Tech Life

“Tons of memories, Ahalia #215 memories on the second floor with Biju sir, Vivek, Dhakad, Rohit, Varad, Raja, Saurabh and others, Cooking with Deed and Dev, The Economics feud, Ahalia Management Memories. Starting with the contesting of elections the whole campaigning and the whole year of experiences as the Gen Sec, Those really fast TT rallies with Arjun Dev after bunking Physics classes, Saharans' last minute class for passing the MDP course, The gym lessons with Prabhjot, The shenanigans of food court trips with the niggers. Shifting to the Nila campus, Manish's piano, suicide attempt and waking up 4 mins before the class and reaching before me, always happy Gopal, Jalpari with his music suggestions, AD and his white t-shirt, Grand Party and G-Party, waiting at the amenity center for hours expecting some food, those COD late night gaming sessions. Arbeque, Malabar and Nominoes trips. Those discussions in the lab complex and Sunset point., Exact 11pm reminders by Nikhil with his defining '4th Year me hai', Water fights birthday celebrations and Meesa's dance. Above all the trips to Kochi, second Kochi, Pondicherry, Munnar, Goa, and 'Black Thunder' in which Meena was the constant.”

If you get a chance to take one person with you back to the hostel who would it be?

“Varad Kausadikar.”

What is one thing you wanted to do in your B.Tech life but couldn't do?

“Whole Kerala Road Trip.”

If you were in charge of planning a concert for the college, which two artists/speakers would you bring?

“Indian Ocean, The Local Train.”



Chaitanya Khawase

Alumnus B'16,
ME

STUDENT ACTIVITIES

Swachhta Pakhwada Competitions Results:

As a part of Swachhta Pakhwada Competition, Graphica organized a Poster making competition which was judged by Mr Sai Vidyananda, alumnus of IIT Palakkad and the ex head of Graphica.

The winners of the competition were as follows:

Students Section:

First prize: Deepankar Sharma

Second prize: Alfin Jaison

Faculties, Staff and their family's section:

First prize: Sanil Sharahudeen

Second prize: Nagesha K

As a part of Swachhta Pakhwada Competition, Akshar organized two events:

1) Essay writing competition

First: Parmeshwar Dewangan(MSc Physics), Shabana K M(PhD CSE)

Second: Rohit Ubnare(MS Civil Engg.)

Third: Amritanshu Raj (BTech B20)

2) Slogan writing competition

1st Position: Amritanshu Raj (B.Tech B20)

2nd Position: Shalvika Alice (MSc Physics)

3rd Position: R Parnika Murty (M.Tech SoCD), Vaibhav B Nagrale (B.Tech B20)

As a part of Swachhta Pakhwada Competition, Finance Club organized a startup pitch competition and the winners were as follows:

First: Amritanshu Raj

Second: Dilip Kalyani

PETRICHOR:

Petrichor launched the very first edition of its flagship event, the National Technology and Entrepreneurship Summit which was conducted virtually for four days: September 16-19. The event was based on the theme- Technology for Tomorrow and was a huge success with participation from all across the nation. A total of 8 eminent speakers from Industry, Academia, Government and from companies such as Samsung India, Wipro, Apna etc interacted with the participants and enlightened them with their rich experience and knowledge. A pitch competition was also conducted as a part of the event with prizes worth 15k. This event was the first-ever student-run summit in Kerala. As our country celebrated its 75th Independence Day this year, Petrichor organized a Digital Poster making competition, Swatantra, on the theme of Independence Day. The competition was open to all the people across India and it witnessed a huge participation.

SPIC MACAY:

SPIC MACAY organized a Carnatic Vocal lecture demo(online) by Vidushi Bombay Jayshree who is an awardee of India's fourth highest civilian award - the Padma Shri in 2021. As IIT Delhi celebrated its diamond jubilee, the movie Kodiyettam was screened on 23 July. This was followed by interaction with the director of the movie Padma Vibhushan Adoor Gopalakrishnan.

VADYA:

Vadya achieved a new milestone as it launched its own YouTube channel- 'Vadya Music Club-IIT Palakkad'. Battle of Bands (BOB 3.0), the much-awaited competition was conducted successfully online this time. After a very interesting round of auctions, the students were divided into 5 teams and each team left no stone unturned to deliver a mind-blowing performance. The battle was even more breathtaking this time as it was Judged by none other than the band 'V Minor' comprising Zubin Imtiaz, Nithin Ramachandran, Fidal and Vinayak Sajeew.

The battle was concluded by a euphonious performance from the judges. It was a tough battle and the winners of BOB 3.0 are:

Winner:

Forgotten Stars (Leader-Harsh, Comprising of: Aniket Singh Rajpoot, Gourav Nishad, Ishmita Kaur, Abhichal Rajput, Rituraj Singh, Joel Sam, Ankit Tiwari)

First Runner up:

Hiraeth (Leader-Jyotiraditya, Comprising of: Jayant Suresh, Anand, Parul Sangwan, Angel Thomson, Haritha, Thacchan Dondup, Shrujan Kanabar, Aravind S, Sai Sathwik Peddireddy)

Second Runner up:

Senfoni (Leader-Olivia, Comprising of: Shivansh Chaudhary, Ritwik P, Sabareesh, Tripti Kundu, Aswin Krishna B, Harsh Dubey, Jeswin Jose)

Class song 2021 which was a tribute to batch 2021 was released this year. The song was composed, performed and edited by students: Ritwik P (Batch 2017), Shivansh Chaudhary (Batch 2020) and Jeswin Jose (Batch 2019). The song was first released as a part of the Battle of Bands competition by Senfoni and it captured everyone's heart following which, it was uploaded to The Happenings IIT Palakkad YouTube channel.

MITRA IIT PALAKKAD

FB Page- Mitra IIT Palakkad Mitra is a team of clinical psychologists, yoga and sport professionals, well trained gatekeepers and faculty advisors in IIT Palakkad. The Mitra IIT Palakkad facebook page is for promoting the mental health service through informative posts about mental health related issues like Creating Hope and Mind full vs Mindful . A video on mental health day (10th Oct.) was shared to spread the importance of mental health awareness. The page also keeps updating the followers about the upcoming events such as the gatekeeper program.

Wellness Club

In the month of October 2021 IIT Palakkad welcomed the Wellness Club. Wellness club's main focus is health and growth: mental, physical, emotional, and social well-being. Students joining the wellness club will get the chance to make new friends, participate and organize campus as well as other physical health-related activities. This will provide them with a break from their academics, allowing them to spare time on their physical and psychological well being.

EML

An EML titled “Career Choices - make it a little wise” was given by Mr. Amal M Das who is the CEO of ARJUNA Group. The motive of the seminar was to give students his words of wisdom, expand their horizons and create new enthusiasm and vigour for their development. Students' questions were collected via google form, which were asked in the Q&A session.

Sports EML

A sports EML by Former Indian Cricketer and current fielding coach of Sunrisers Hyderabad by Mr. Biju George was organised. He also served as the fielding coach in the Indian Women's Cricket team and U-19 Indian team. Students were given the opportunity to send their question via a google form or ask them directly during the meeting.

ALUMNI CELL

Alumni Cell Ceremony & Faculty Alumni Meet

The induction ceremony of the new Alumni Cell team was organised by the Alumni Cell. The certificates for undergraduates research and innovation award was also presented during the ceremony. The Faculty Alumni Meet, 2021 commenced after the induction ceremony of the new Alumni Cell team which included an interaction session with the director and a branch wise session with the faculty.

A Day at Work- L&T

A Day at Work is a series of events to provide a platform for the students to interact with the Alumni's working in the big companies and know about the work culture of popular companies. In the first edition of the series, Alumni Rishabh Kumar Jaiswal & Harsh from Larsen & Toubro shared their experience from the recruitment process to a typical day at work.

Talk on the Automotive Sector

The Alumni Cell conducted an interactive session on the Automotive Sector between students and two alumni's Mr Praveen Zalaya and Mr Gauri Shankar Prasad. Mr. Praveen Zalaya pursued MS from Automotive Engineering from Politecnico di Torino and is currently working as a Controls Team Member at Squadra Corse DRIVERLESS, Polito and Mr. Gauri Shankar Prasad completed his masters in Mobility Engineering from Politecnico di Milano, Italy. Mr. Praveen also shared some guiding materials for the students interested in pursuing a career in the Automotive field

TFS

Exodus: Alumni Interview Series

In the Exodus alumni interview series, interviews with various alumni are being conducted to get their input on various matters, with the hopes that readers will gain useful insights about their life at IIT and after it. Questions range from their views on joining IIT Palakkad and their four most important years of life at IIT Palakkad, to their life after getting placed and how they have transformed in all those years.

The first issue of the interview with Ankit Singh, Alumni of IIT Palakkad was shared. He shared his experience at IIT Palakkad and views on the academics and other matters such as conducting the first Fest of IIT Palakkad.

AKSHAR :

DOCUMENTARY CASE STUDY COMPETITION

The literary arts club came up with the very unique idea of a documentary case study competition which was focused on giving students an opportunity to be a critic and to review the documentary shown to them. The competition saw massive participation among the students. The result of this competition were:

1st Position : Anurag Jha, B.Tech B19

2nd Position : Amritanshu Raj, B.Tech B20

3rd Position : Gowtham Kori, B.Tech B20

4th Position : Ananya Sinha, M.Sc. Chemistry

5th Position : Tripathi Siddharth Sudhakar, M.Tech PEPS

CREATIVE WRITING COMPETITION:

Akshar held the creative writing competition in which a number of prompts were provided by the organisers on which students had to show their creativity and come up with any of the following:- a story, an article, an essay, a poem etc. The winners of this competition & their entries were:

1st Position: Arjun Satheesh, B Tech 2019-The Writer's Block

2nd Position: Shreya M P, Batch 2019-The Mystery of the Second Rock

3rd Position: Jayasurya R, Batch 2020-APRIL

3rd Position: Lekshmi R Nair, Batch 2020-Stranger, My Lover

GRAFICA

Grafica held a pencil drawing Competition on the general theme. The winners of the Pencil drawing competition were:

1st Position : Sourav Sen, M.Tech- Power Electronics and Power System

2nd Position : Srinath G, M.Sc Mathematics

3rd Position : K C Kalam Aswathy, PhD B19

Honorable Mention : Rapeti Siddhu Neehal, Btech 2020

Honorable Mention : R.Rohith, MSc Chemistry

SHUTTERBUG

Shutterbug held a photography competition named In Frame, A Theme based Photography Competition. The themes for the competition were Object or gadget photography, Indoor games & Shadows. The winners of the competition were:

First Prize : Saumil Gupta, Btech 20

Second Prize : Akhil MV, Btech 20

Third Prize : Bhavana Sharma, Mtech 20

World Photography day:

World Photography Day, which is observed on August 19 every year, Shutterbug held an event this year named Caption the Capture. In which students were asked to caption the wonderful photographs captured by the students of IIT Palakkad.

SPORTS COUNCIL

Virtual General Championship Winners

The sports council declared the B.tech batch 2019 as winner of the virtual general Championship. A Virtual Marathon was held by the sports council to conclude the Virtual General Championship

QUIZ CLUB

Quiz Series

The Quiz Club decided to start off by establishing its presence on social media. The members posted a set of questions every Sunday for others to answer and gave away prize money for the winners. The competition was pretty cut throat.

India Quiz result

In the spirit of Independence Day, the Quiz Club decided to find how much do our students exactly know about this nation we call home. Quite a few people participated in this event which turned out to be a really fun way to brush up on our history. A preliminary round was held, after which there was the final showdown. The winners of the competition were Ayush Singh and Sneha Bhattacharjee, with the runners-up being Gregory Paul T and Abraham Aby followed by Joel Joy and Deon Saji.

TECHNICAL :**Tech Day : (Aug 19 - Sept 11)****DATA DERBY:**

There were 3 problem statements based on which contestants have to come up with a model (restrictions on model's if any will be provided in the problem description) to solve the problem.

Winner- RK Raj Surya

Highest accuracy in the first problem-Ayush Singh

Highest accuracy in the second problem-Yogesh R

THINKER-THON:

Thinker-Thon was a problem-solving hackathon where participants ponder into the given problem statements and come up with efficient ideas to solve the given problem.

Winners :

1. Teslayers :

Shalvika Alice

Parmeshwar Dewangan

2. Minions

Keerthana P

Mythili A

Abhirami K

3. Odeep

Sandeep Kumar Mahto

OPEN PROJECT:

A student should come up with a system using any microcontroller (Arduino , Raspberry Pi ,Frdm board etc) and sensors that could improve the functionality of an automotive vehicle. The system can be an innovative one or an existing one.

Winners :

Joel Joy

Arjun V

CAD-WARS:

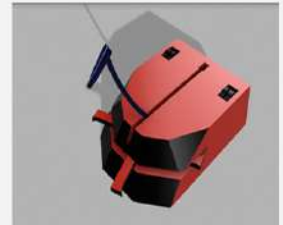
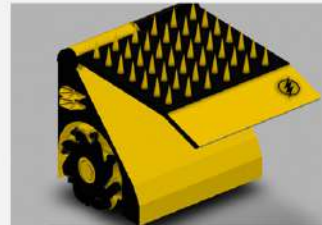
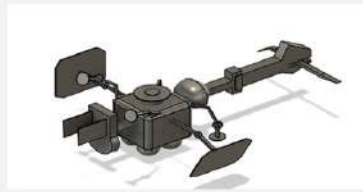
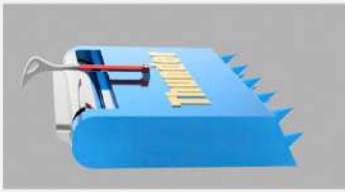
Participants were required to design mini war robots according to space, mobility and weapon restrictions. A great set of entries were submitted which made it hard for judges to rule out the best. Points were given according to the design features, adherence to the rulebook and aesthetics of the designs. Cad wars witnessed a good no. of talented designers showcasing their modelling skills meeting up with a deadline.

Winners :

Saurabh Kumar Pandey

Piyush Gaikwad

Rekala Sai Bharani



CODING COMPETITION:

A CP contest of duration 2 to 2.5 hr consisting of 5- 7 problems for students of all batches. The problems were of varying difficulty to encourage participation from newbies.

Winners :

Nideesh N

Aditya Agarwal

CRYPTO-TRADING COMPETITION:

The first steps to getting involved with cryptocurrency whether to invest or to get live experience by trading cryptocurrency. People are reluctant to learn about it because it scares them and it is complicated, but it doesn't have to be. The competition was hosted on the Roostoo app,

Winners :

Paul Tony

Shiv Kumar Suthar

Juttu Gajendra Anurag

QUANTUM COMPUTING CLUB:

1) Introductory Session

The Quantum Computing Club had an introductory session on 26th September.

In this session, the concept of quantum computing was introduced. The difference between a classical bit of computation and a qubit or a quantum bit was emphasized. The future of quantum computing was also discussed.

2) Introduction to Linear Algebra for Quantum Computing

The Quantum Computing Club had a session on Introduction to Linear Algebra for Quantum Computing on 17th October

The knowledge of Linear Algebra is of paramount importance in Quantum Computing. So in this session, the basics of linear algebra needed for quantum computing were introduced.

FOOTPRINTS INTERVIEW :

Dr. Deepak Rajendraprasad

Assistant Professor, Computer Science And Engineering



1. Describe what a normal day looks like in your life (daily routine wake-up to bed)?

BC (Before Covid): Cock-a-doodle-doo alarm, coffee (no milk, no sugar, no chicory) , The Hindu, breakfast, drop my son at his bus stop, 30 kilometers with my Zen, class/research/email, coffee (no milk, no sugar) at Manjunath's, class/research/email/meetings, lunch (rice and fish) with Biju and others from one of the small eateries outside Ahalia green gate, soda lime at Manjunath's, email/spreadsheets/meetings, coffee (you know) at Manjunath's, research/meetings till 5, preparation for next class till 7, 30 kilometers with my Zen, dinner with family, youtube (football, finely choreographed action sequences in movies, or long speeches/podcasts), pending class preparation, sleep. Or so I wish.

CE (Covid Era): Cock-a-doodle-doo alarm, snooze, Cock-a-doodle-doo alarm, coffee (no milk, no sugar, no chicory) , The Hindu, breakfast, google calendar, zoom, google meet, zoom, google meet, laptop to tablet, tablet to phone, phone to tablet,

2. A day without teaching/administrative/research duties (no institute-related work), how would you want to spend it?

On my arm chair or bed, awake but dreaming, with a coffee mug that never empties.

3. We know you received your early training in Electronics & Communication. You did your B.tech, M.E and you were even lecturer at NIT Calicut in the same area. But you decided to do your PhD in Computer Science and not just that your thesis was in graph theory (theoretical CS and E&C not much in common, hence the surprise). Could you tell us how this happened ?

This is what a mix of wrong company and overconfidence can do to you. While I was a lecturer in NIT Calicut, I was in constant contact with Murali Krishnan who was teaching in the CS department there. Apart from the many long academic discussions that we had, I attended his course on Advanced Algorithms and was amazed at how ideas from Algebra, Probability, Linear Algebra, Number theory and so on gets used to design surprising algorithms. The highlight of that course was the AKS primality testing algorithm- arguably the most famous contribution to theoretical CS from India. At that time I was also offering a course on Communication Switching Systems to EC students and it involved a lot of graph theory- like bipartite matching and stuff. Somehow, these things felt more appealing to me. There is both a puzzle-like cuteness and a philosophy-like depth to theoretical CS. Once I started my research in it, I fell in love, the kind of bond which nothing short of death can part :)

4. You did your Postdoc at University of Haifa, Israel. Could you tell me about your experience during your time there... Like things you've learnt (habits, morals etc.) and how your experience there changed you as a person, researcher and an academic? Many notable Scientists are Jewish (Einstein, R. Feynman, John Neumann etc.), is there something about their work ethic and lifestyle that you think cultivates their hard working nature?

Academically, Israel is a fantastic place. Probably it has the highest density of professional mathematicians. I was fortunate to have collaborated with the best minds in my field during my stay there. Personally, I don't think it changed me much as a person except that I discovered my passion for cooking.

Several factors may have contributed to the fact that so many exceptional brains come from there. The community regards intellectual achievements very high and this echoes in the dinner tables of many families. I think kids get motivated by these stories. Israel has an accelerated learning program for exceptionally bright students, but I think it is relatively new and may not explain the long line of greats. You can defer the compulsory military service if you demonstrate exceptional academic achievements in high school. That's quite a motivation for some. Once the modern state of Israel was formed, from the community which was spread all around the world, many returned to Israel. Some of them were exceptionally high achievers and had top-class exposure. They were instrumental in building the modern educational system in Israel. I'm not sure which all of these factors contribute in what amount. But I think the cultural factor that they regard intellectual achievement as a pride as well as a path to prosperity may be one of the most important factors.

5. On behalf of students who have taken your courses, Your pedagogy and paper setting style is well liked by many students, even those who aren't particularly fond of theoretical Computer Science. Who were some of your inspirations that shaped you to be the teacher you are now?

Many of my teachers have inspired me in different ways. Manjunath (Math, IISc, one of my favourite teachers) showed me the magic that happens when everyone- most importantly the teacher- is relaxed in class. He proved multiple times that if you are relaxed in class, you can get across the most complicated stuff. Sunil (CSA, IISc, my PhD adviser) showed me that if you can latch onto a student's attempt to answer your question, and partner with her right in the class to push her idea to its limit, then you have the heart of one and ears of many more. Rajeev Sir (one of my BTech teachers) showed me that you should never hide your passion for the subject that you are teaching because passion is contagious. Murali (CSE, NIT Calicut, Jasine's husband) taught me that classes can have a rhythm. There are many more. But I think my role model as a teacher would be Baiju Sir; who never taught me a course; but was my mentor and critique when I started my teaching career. He insisted that no rule, no style, no charm, no inspiration can substitute for three hours of thorough preparation before any class. He convinced me that knowing the content is only the beginning. The details of delivery have to be thought through each time with a creative mind.

6. Just recently you stepped down from the post of Associate Dean (Academics, UG). On behalf of the entire IIT Palakkad community we thank you for your work. Research (focused thoughts) and Administration (attending to others' needs at any time) have very different requirements and some would even say diametrically opposite. What were some things you learnt during your time in this administrative role? How were you able to strike a balance between all these responsibilities? Any final words of wisdom from your experience?

This was the first big administrative role that I had taken up in my life. For someone who was instinctively anti-establishment all his past, this was a difficult role to play. But IIT Palakkad is still a small enough place that you know most of the community in person. Hence there is a very high level of goodwill and trust and also a feeling of collective responsibility. This helps you a lot when you are in an administrative role. I have been helped innumerable times by my colleagues and student representatives.

I wasn't really successful in striking that balance you mentioned. The deanship meant that I could not ignore my inbox and phone for too long. But in order to make a significant improvement in my understanding of a research problem that I'm thinking about, I have to kind of submit myself to the problem and allow the problem to hold me captive for as long as it likes. This is not easy when suddenly each item in your not-done list pops up inside your head and a tide of guilt swells up and swallows you from within. Most of the time, I ended up in a limbo doing neither this nor that.

Wisdom from this experience? It's more of a realization. A realisation that everything in an autonomous institute- from the position of a greenboard in a classroom, to the curriculum of a programme- is there that way because someone in the institute thought it out, argued it through, and set it up there that way.

7. Does IIT Palakkad plan to start a new B.tech Program any time soon, given that some of the other younger IITs have started. What is this B.tech program likely to be? And when is it likely to start?

Though not finalised, all indications are that the next B.Tech program in IIT Palakkad will be broadly in the area of Data Science and Machine Learning. A separate Department of Data Science has already been formed at IIT Palakkad.

8. As a member of the faculty of IIT Palakkad, can you tell us a little about the vision our institute has for itself? More importantly, how does IIT Palakkad want to answer the question "Why IIT Palakkad"? (goals, visions, dreams of the institute - why new biomedical department? Why new mtech etc. these are things that many alumni and students don't know the reason for including myself, this question is asked with an intent to get information on some of the new developments)

IIT Palakkad's tagline- "Nurturing minds for a better world", is a pointer towards its vision. Discussions have already been initiated for framing a vision for the institute. I think, now that we have a considerable strength in terms of students, alumni, faculty and staff, it is a good time to open up a discussion among all these groups about the larger vision of the institute.

In my opinion, we should not try to define ourselves in terms of what makes it unique or different. We should draw our vision from the eager eyes of a freshman who enters its gates and not from the judgemental helicopter eyes of professional reviewing/rating agencies. IIT Palakkad has realised that on the research side, more emphasis should be given for interdisciplinary research as many problems can be solved by people from different areas and expertise. Speaking of the BioMedical department, even IISc is going to start a new MBBS programme. Many innovative and wonderful results can be achieved by Engineering and Medicine researchers working together. Another centre that has come up is on sustainability. It is important that we invest on research pertaining to sustainability. Even when all these departments were formed, it was taken care not to split the research that is happening in the institute, essentially keeping PhD and research students as a floating population, managed by a central system. This interdisciplinarity is always kept in mind even while forming new MTech programmes. The MTech in Data Science is a joint venture of many departments, MTech in SoCD is jointly provided by the Computer Science and Electrical departments. Besides on the practical side, available expertise is also a deciding factor. A new MTech programme cannot be started unless there are at least 4-5 faculties who have expertise in that area. So these factors influence the decisions on starting new MTech programmes.

9. Finally, a message you would like to give to the IIT Palakkad student community?

Keep an open mind. Don't let your prejudices about yourself close the doors on anything.